

SEX OFFENSES: PROJECTED GROWTH & IMPACT OF LONGER TIME SERVED

April 2025

Issue Brief: Individuals serving time for a sex offense make up the largest share of Utah's prison population. This brief examines 10-year growth projections for this population, highlighting newly passed legislation and its expected impact on prison beds and taxpayer costs.

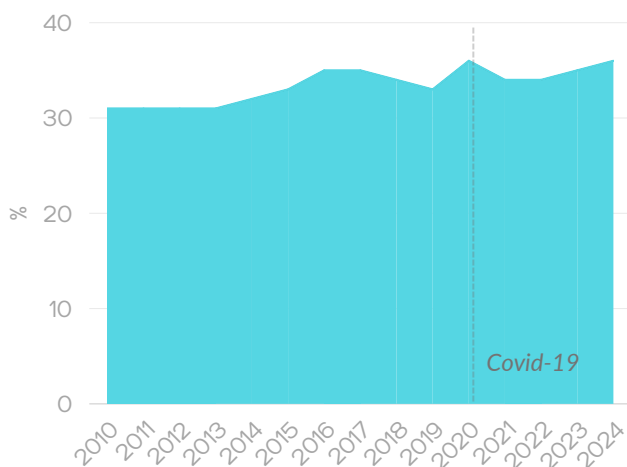
At a Glance

Sex offenses make up the largest share of Utah's prison population with its share growing in the past decade. In 2024, around 2,300 individuals in Utah's state prison served time for a sex offense, comprising over 35% of the inmate population. The majority of these individuals are male (~98%).

Admissions & Releases

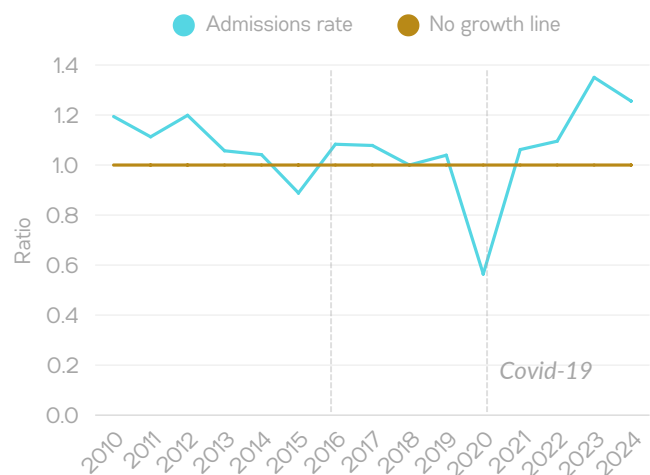
Between 2019 and 2024, 1.1 sex offenders were admitted for every person released, leading to population growth. As seen in Figure 2, the population has generally stayed above the "no growth line", with temporary declines during justice reform (2016) and COVID-19.

Figure 1: Percent of Utah's Prison Population Serving Time for a Sex Offense



Part of the UPPP Policy Brief Series

Figure 2: Prison Admissions/Releases: 2010-24



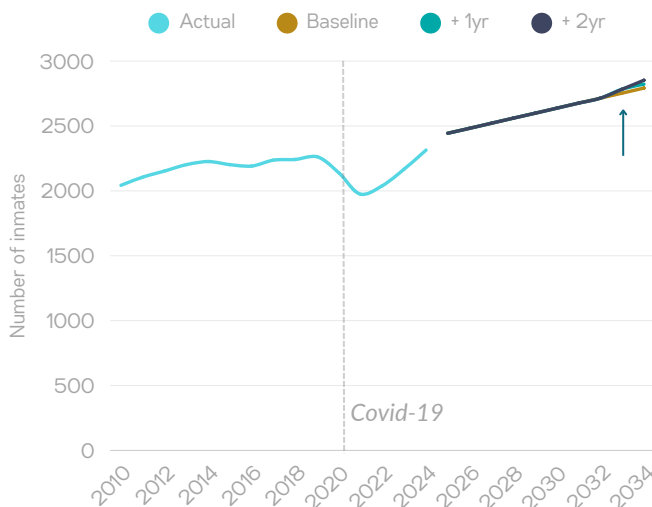
Admissions of sex offenders have traditionally exceeded releases, resulting in population growth.

Projected Growth & New Legislation

While briefly reduced during COVID-19, Utah's sex offender population experienced upward pressure in the past 14 years. Absent any significant policy interventions, it is predicted that the population will continue to increase in the next decade, reaching around 2,700 individuals by 2034.

Recent legislation, such as [HB207](#), that raises mandatory minimums for a subset of this population may affect current projections. Assuming the average time served of 8 years increases between 1-2 years per person and that the bill will affect an estimated 20% of new admissions for sex offenders convicted of a Felony 2 and 3 degree, the projected growth will start to increase in 2033 and grow each year. This added growth reflects the cumulative effect of increased time served.

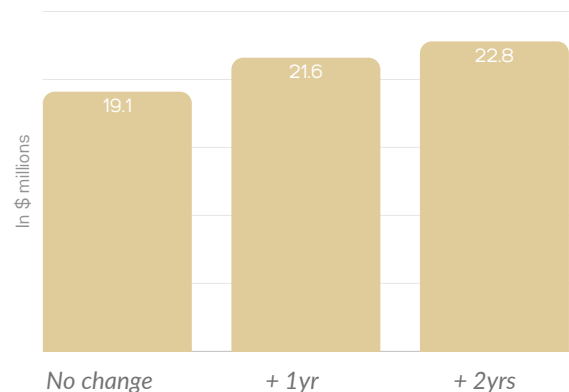
Figure 3: Utah Prison Population (sex offenses): Actual vs Projected: 2010-2034



Learn about our methodology [here](#)

Figure 4 presents the projected 10-year baseline cost for Utah taxpayers, estimated at \$19.1 million (assuming an annual per person cost of \$40,000 and adjusted for 2% annual inflation). This expected cost would increase to \$21.6 to \$22.8 million depending on the average increase in time served for persons impacted by HB207.

Figure 4: Estimated 10-Year Cost of Growth Under Different Time Served Scenarios



\$19M in baseline 10-year projected growth cost

+\$2.4M additional for every one-year increase in time served

Conclusion

Balancing public safety and taxpayer costs remains an ongoing goal for Utah lawmakers. Legislation that may increase time served is projected to increase long-term prison bed needs and costs for this population, driving further population growth. More analysis is needed to refine these estimates.